Tiny Snakes Roll to Escape Danger, Four Times Faster Than Slithering

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Imagine a tiny snake that does not **slither** away from danger. It rolls! **Dwarf reedsnakes** in Southeast Asia can roll about four times faster than they **slither**, and scientists have worked out how they do it.

Rolling sounds easy, but for an animal it is hard. A wheel turns around a fixed **axle** while the load it carries stays still. An animal has no **axle**, so if its whole body spins, its head spins too, making balance and steering much harder.

Scientists filmed the snakes from several angles. While rolling, they reached peak speeds of 1.72 to 3.69 metres per second, about four times their fastest **slithering** speed. Even at that speed, they stayed on a racetrack only 20 centimetres wide, so this is not wild **tumbling**.

Their secret is careful timing. They roll on one side, then swing a curved part of the body downward beside the head, a move researchers called a **stroke**. With each cycle, the side touching the ground switches. Best of all, the head stays out of the spin and points forward, like a steady lookout.

Word Treasure

slither -- To slither is to slide along the ground the way a snake does.

axle -- An axle is the bar in the middle of a wheel that the wheel turns around.

stroke -- Here, a stroke is one special swing of the snake's body that helps it roll.

Dwarf reedsnakes -- Dwarf reedsnakes are a kind of very small snake that lives in Southeast Asia.

tumbling -- Tumbling means rolling over and over without control.

Background you need

Snakes usually move by slithering, sliding their bodies along the ground.

Rolling is a much faster way to escape, but it is hard for an animal because it has no wheel or axle to spin around.

Scientists filmed these tiny snakes to learn how they roll without losing their balance.

Break it down

WHO: Dwarf reedsnakes in Southeast Asia and the scientists who filmed them.
WHAT: The snakes roll to escape danger instead of slithering.
WHERE: Southeast Asia, studied on a narrow racetrack in the scientists' tests.
WHY: Rolling is about four times faster than slithering, so it helps them escape danger quickly.

Why it matters

It shows how animals can solve a tricky movement problem in a clever way, just like you might find a faster way to do something hard.

Test what you remember

1. How do dwarf reedsnakes escape danger?

- (A) They roll away
- (B) They swim away
- (C) They climb trees
- (D) They hide underground

2. How does rolling speed compare with slithering speed?

- (A) Ten times faster
- (B) About four times faster
- (C) About the same speed
- (D) Half as fast

3. What problem does an animal face when it rolls?

- (A) It loses its skin
- (B) It cannot breathe
- (C) Its tail falls off
- (D) Its head spins too

4. How did scientists study the snakes?

- (A) They chased them in the wild
- (B) They filmed them from several angles
- (C) They kept them as pets
- (D) They drew pictures of them

5. What is a stroke in this story?

- (A) A swimming move
- (B) A kind of snake bite
- (C) A curved part of the body swinging downward beside the head
- (D) A loud sound the snake makes

6. What stays steady while the snake rolls?

- (A) Its eyes close
- (B) Its head points forward
- (C) Its whole body stays still
- (D) Its tail points backward

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: D 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):